

George Attla Graces Minnesota Trails with Good Will

The following article is compiled from an article from *Anishinaabeg Today*, by Gary W. Padra, February, 1999, and an article by Tom Kjos from the *Detroit Lakes Tribune*.

Renowned Alaska musher George Attla honored many race trails this past season with his presence. Arriving on

Attla's appearance enabled the kids to get some extra tips from the pro, and he must have given some good advice to Larson's students, for in the Monticello Harry Wheeler's Children's Race, Chilton finished third in the four-dog race, and Rogers finished third in the three-dog race. Rogers also won the coveted sportsman award.



George Attla (back row on table) and the juniors from the Monticello Children's Harry Wheeler Race for Muscular Dystrophy, Monticello, MN, February, 1999
Photo by Lynn Congdon

February 2nd, he was hosted by musher Rick Larson of Richwood, Minnesota, on the White Earth Indian Reservation, and his support cast of sixteen canine Alaskan husky helpers, whose names include Turbo, Smoky and Shoes, and three reservation children whom he has taken under his wing to teach them the fun of sled dog racing. They are Richard Hamlin, 15, of Richwood; Eric Chilton, 14, from Strawberry Lake; and John Henry Rodgers, 11, from White Earth.

"The kids need a positive role model," said Larson. "Dog sledding has very traditional ties to the Native people. The bottom line is it's good for the kids. I'm rewarded by seeing the smiles on their faces."

"Working with the dogs is pretty cool," said Hamlin, as the other kids nodded. They all agreed they would never have gotten the chance to race if it weren't for Larson. Chilton said they practice at Larson's place two to three times a week and enter races almost every weekend.

blessed the dogs and the trail with sprinklings of tobacco. Attla also provided a tension reliever for racers and audience with his rendition of a humorous bear story. He took the opportunity to examine racers' dogs and sign autographs as well.

From Hinckley he went to Monticello, Minnesota, for the Harry Wheeler Children's Race for Muscular Dystrophy. There he acted as race marshal and made a hit with the young competitors, gathering them together Saturday evening for story telling and discussions about great lead dogs, training, and what he looks for in a dog. During the weekend he was also charmed by the lovely Deye sisters, Cindy and Jenny, of Cambridge, MN.

During a lay over at Larson's, during which he worked with Larson's three junior mushers, Attla told the young John Henry Rogers, "Hey, little round face, I've been running dogs forty years and only won one sports award. You should be proud." John Henry's face beamed,

and he didn't come off this "high" for days, according to Larson.

The following weekend Attla lastly made an appearance at the Third Annual Polar Dash Sled Dog Race at Detroit Lakes Feb. 13th and 14th, where he was just your average, everyday spectator. Several mushers, including Merv Hilpiper of Iowa, against whom Attla had previously raced, were on hand to refresh him with rich memories and laughs of the "old days."

George seemed to enjoy himself immensely. He was especially impressed with the way Larson was working with the Native American kids and involving them in such a wholesome sport. He complimented the well organized group of mushers he met in Minnesota and was delighted with the commitment to the junior mushers made by North Star Sled Dog Club. As a bonus, he invited Larson and the three young mushers up to his North Pole, Alaska, kennel for some good times and good training.

Attla was officially voted an honorary membership in North Star at its April meeting. His racing career is impressive. He is the ten-time winner of the Alascom Open North American Championships in Fairbanks and has won the Anchorage Fur Rendezvous eight times. The 1982 movie, *Spirit of the Wind*, is about his life. He also co-authored with Bella Levorsen a how-to book entitled *All I Know about Training and Racing Sled Dogs*. *



George Attla & John Henry Rogers (with Harry Wheeler Sportsman Trophy)
Photo by Lynn Congdon